

A week in, fire crews soldier on

With extreme winds still expected, hot spots and containment lines are the focus



FIREFIGHTERS from the California Conservation Corps work on Monday in Altadena on the Eaton fire, 35% contained as of Tuesday.

CRISIS MAY TEST UTILITY LIABILITY FUND

BY JENNY JARVIE

Five years ago, Pacific Gas & Electric filed for bankruptcy after it was found liable for sparking a succession of devastating wildfires, including the blaze that destroyed the town of Paradise and led to more than 100 deaths.

Wall Street investors lost confidence and ratings agencies threatened to downgrade California's investor-owned utilities, prompting legislators to come up with an innovative solution: the establishment of a \$21-billion wildfire fund, split equally between shareholders and utility customers.

Now, after two major wildfires have destroyed thousands of homes and left at least two dozen dead in and around Los Angeles, the state's wildfire fund would face its first major test if another utility is found liable for sparking the blazes.

Even the lawmaker who

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How to apply for FEMA aid

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No guarantees on federal relief

State may face an uphill fight for continued funding in a GOP-led Congress. **NATION, A14**

Housing-related assistance, advice

What evacuees should know about mortgages, rents, utility bills and federal aid. **BUSINESS, A10**

Newsom proposes disaster funds

A \$2.5-billion request is added to a legislative session originally focused on Trump. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Edison's inspection pace faulted

In October report, state regulators criticized the utility for falling behind in assessing safety of transmission lines in high-risk areas

BY MELODY PETERSEN
AND JENNY JARVIE

State regulators criticized Southern California Edison Co. for falling behind in inspecting transmission lines in areas at high risk of wildfires just months before the deadly Eaton fire, according to state documents.

Utility safety officials also said the company's visual inspections of splices in its transmission lines were sometimes failing to find dangerous problems, according to their October report. Instead, those problems were not discovered until the company inspected the lines with X-ray equipment, which is used far less frequently.

The report by the California Office of Energy Infrastructure Safety was issued less than three months before devastating wildfires broke out in Los Angeles County last week. [See **Edison, A8**]



EDISON SAID its analysis showed that its equipment didn't start the Eaton fire. Above, a PG&E crew works in Altadena on Monday.



CAROL MAYORGA, pictured with her son Bryan Salazar, worked with her husband as housekeepers for clients in Pacific Palisades whose homes burned down.

'They lost their homes,' and these workers lost their jobs

BY BRITTNY MEJIA
AND RUBEN VIVES

Carol Mayorga and Manfredo Salazar spent more time in Pacific Palisades than they did their own South Los Angeles neighborhood.

It was their bank account. It paid their mort-

gage. It was the place where their 13-year-old son had long attended school, and where — after their decades of working there — employers became as close as family.

So when Pacific Palisades burned, Mayorga and Salazar's livelihood went up in flames too.

Their own three-bed-

room home still stands, but nearly 10 properties where Mayorga and Salazar worked as housekeepers are gone. The condo building where Salazar worked in maintenance, cleaning the hallways and public spaces, is still standing, but it's inaccessible. The two-day-a-week job their daughter,

The air attack that held the lines

BY GRACE TOOHEY

On Friday afternoon, the winds across the Santa Monica Mountains suddenly shifted, and the Palisades fire pushed north and east, making a run in two different directions: toward Encino and Brentwood.

Across the southern San Fernando Valley and West L.A., terrified Angelenos watched as leaping flames and massive plumes of smoke continued to rise over ridgelines well into the night, worried that the already catastrophic blaze could devastate new parts of the city.

But this time, there were two critical differences in the firefight: There was a squadron of massive water- and retardant-dropping aircraft at the ready, and winds — although strong — still allowed for them to take flight.

So pilots went to work.

The next 24 hours became an all-out attack of air resources, with enough helicopters responding to the

BY HANNAH FRY,
RONG-GONG LIN II,
NATHAN SOLIS
AND GRACE TOOHEY

A week after flames leveled huge swaths of Pacific Palisades and Altadena, Southern California remained under a severe fire threat as residents still struggled to comprehend the scale of the loss.

An army of firefighters spent Tuesday putting out small fires before they got out of control, and continued building containment lines on the Palisades and Eaton fires in hope of preventing them from spreading. The firestorm is expected to be the most costly in U.S. history, consuming what officials estimate could be more than 12,000 structures, including many homes.

"This is the most devastating natural disaster to hit the Los Angeles area," said L.A. Fire Department Capt. Erik Scott. "I've worked here for 20 years and I've never seen nor imagined devastation to be this extensive."

The reality of the losses came into greater focus as residents lined up Tuesday at two Federal Emergency Management Agency disaster recovery centers opened to assist people whose homes and belongings were destroyed in the fires.

Sonja Jackson waited outside the center with her 3-year-old granddaughter, Amirah, and her 9-year-old son, Aaden, looking for some guidance after her family's initial application for assistance was denied.

The Eaton fire destroyed Jackson's home in Altadena, her mother's home and her daughter's home in a matter of hours. The family cat, Marshmallow, is still missing.

"We all left with the clothes on our back," Jackson, 45, said. "We thought we'd be able to come back in the morning. We didn't think the fires were gonna do what they did."

Jackson, a nurse, now finds herself along with as many as nine family members crammed into her aunt's home. She's hoping to secure some type of temporary housing while she and her family get back on their feet, but her insurance provider, Allstate, will cover only a two-night stay at a hotel. Her plan will also cover only \$20,000 for personal items lost in the fire, Jackson said.

"Which does nothing," Jackson said. "I lost appli-



PETE HEGSETH at his Senate confirmation hearing Tuesday.

Hegseth faces Senate scrutiny

Nominee for Defense secretary deflects misconduct allegations and focuses on his service. **NATION, A4**

Resilient Rams make statement

In a stadium that became home away from home due to fires, players respond with playoff win. **SPORTS, B10**

Weather Sunshine.

L.A. Basin: 74/46. **B5**

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